coursera

Depressive and Bipolar Disorders ✕

Today's goal • 3/3 items

Module 1
Learn With PsycLearn Essentials

Module 2
Opening to Depressive and Bipolar Disorders

Module 3
Depressive and Bipolar Disorders

Module 4
Biological Contributing Factors

Lesson 5: Genetic Contributing Factors
- ✓ Developmental Psychopathology
  Reading • 3 min
- ✓ Genetic Contributing Factors
  Reading • 3 min
- ✓ The Link Between Genes and Psychopathology
  Video • 4 min
- ✓ Practical Scenario
  Real-world application • 5 min
- ✓ Genetic Contributing Factors for Depression
  Reading • 10 min
- ✓ Epigenetic Contributors to Depression
  Video • 3 min
- ✓ Genetic Contributing Factors for Bipolar Disorder
  Reading • 3 min
- ○ Check Your Understanding: Genetic Contributing Factors
  Practice Assignment • 4 min

Lesson 6: Neurobiological Contributing Factors
- ○ **Depressive Disorders: A Case Study**
  Reading • 5 min
- ○ Communication in the Synapse
  Video • 4 min
- ○ Neurochemical Contributors to Depression
  Reading • 10 min
- ○ Practical Scenario
  Real-world application • 5 min
- ○ Hormonal Contributors to Depression
  Reading • 5 min
- ○ Brain Regions Linked to Depression
  Video • 4 min
- ○ Neurobiological Contributors to Depressive and Bipolar Disorders
  Reading • 15 min
- ○ Check Your Understanding: Biological Contributing Factors
  Practice Assignment • 6 min

Key Takeaways
- ○ Key Takeaways: Biological Contributing Factors
  Reading • 10 min

Module 4 Quiz
- ○ Module Quiz: Biological Contributing Factors
  Graded Assignment • 9 min

Module 5
Psychological Contributing Factors

Module 6
Treatments for Depressive and Bipolar Disorders

Module 7
Suicide

Module 8
Conclusion

Module 9
Cumulative Quiz

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Course Resources

Module 11
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Depressive Disorders: A Case Study

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To help focus on the variety of biological causes of depression, let's take a look at a case study.

Scenario

Ashley is a 22 year old suffering from a severe depressive episode. From her perspective, the role that biology plays in her depression is simple. She knows that her doctor has prescribed a medication that is designed to raise her serotonin levels; therefore, she believes that she's depressed due to a lack of serotonin. Although this statement may be true, the relationship between depression and neurotransmitters is far more complex.

Simply put, because depression involves many brain areas, each of which can employ several different neurotransmitters, linking a disorder such as depression to a single neurotransmitter is an oversimplification. Current theories of depression acknowledge the important roles that the neurotransmitters noradrenaline and GABA (Luscher et al., 2011, Moret & Briley, 2011) can also play in the disorder's development and suggest that the balance of different neurotransmitters may be more important than the absolute levels of any particular one.

End of Scenario

If Ashley's depression is due to an imbalance of various neurotransmitters in her brain, then how does their presence, or absence, actually affect the brain?

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